Wonder On Paper

By Mary Hall Surface

INTRODUCTION

When anything can be looked up at a moment's notice, does it actually have any meaning? To take it a step further, can a child growing up in a fast-paced technology-based world learn to appreciate beauty? The communication divide between those who attempt to find meaning and beauty and those who don't take the time is shown in Wonder On Paper by Marry Hall Surface.

RUSSELL: Shel? (*Sees her.*) Great. Got the right gallery. Thought I'd taken a wrong turn at the sphinx. What's up with the litter?

SHELLY: (*drawing*) I'll pick it up. What time is it?

RUSSELL: (*checking the clock on his cell phone*) Three o'clock. Exactly. I had my phone alarm programmed to beep in increasingly smaller intervals, with a mounting sense of urgency.

SHELLY: It can do that?

RUSSELL: Man and machine. We can do anything. Come on, we gotta go!

SHELLY: Can't.

RUSSELL: We promised Dad in blood we'd taxi back to the hotel by 3:30.

SHELLY: Can't.

RUSSELL: (*rapidly picking up SHELLY's discarded drawings, shoving them into her backpack*) Shelly, if we blow this, our vacation is doomed! They won't let us out of their sight again!

SHELLY: I can't leave until I draw "beauty."

RUSSELL: Do what?

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SHELLY: "Beauty." What is it? I want to draw it.

RUSSELL: It's summer, Shel. Honors art class is over.

SHELLY: This is for me! I've spent all day in this museum filled with gorgeous paintings and sculptures that artists have made for thousands of years-

RUSSELL: So draw one of those. (*Checking his clock.*) Quickly!

SHELLY: But they're beautiful *things*-not beauty itself. That's what I want to capture!

RUSSELL: OK. We'll look it up.

SHELLY: What?

RUSSELL: (*punching keys on his cell phone)* Oxford English Dictionary. On-line. Mobile access. Definition: "Beauty."

SHELLY: Russel-

RUSSELL: Shelly. I have the information. The Knowledge.

SHELLY: You have a cell phone.

RUSSELL: I have the Holy Grail of access, a golden bowl of answers. But I can sign off-

SHELLY: Wait! What does it say?

RUSSELL: (*reading from his Web access*) "Beauty: A quality that pleases the mind or sense." There you go. (*SHELLY does not move.*) So draw!

SHELLY: How do you draw that: a "quality"?

RUSSELL: You're an artist, Shel. Figure it our or give it up.

SHELLY: Is that your philosophy of life?

RUSSELL: Excuse me?

SHELLY: Anything you can't figure out, you just don't think about?

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RUSSELL: Yes. Exactly! (*Looking at his phone.*) Depleting power bar. Now we really have to go.

SHELLY: Look at this statue.

RUSSELL: Shelly-

SHELLY: I need five minutes. Time me!

RUSSELL: (*programming the phone*) Deal. Four fifty-nine and counting.

SHELLY: (*looking at the statue*) Do you see?

RUSSELL: (*reading the label*) "Egyptian. 2500 B.C. Sandstone. Ra, the sun god." And?

SHELLY: Whoever carved this wanted to know how the sun rises and sets. So he made a god.

RUSSELL: Who sailed in a golden boat across the sky, until sunset. I know all about him. Then he road down into the underworld, and rose again at sunrise. Sunset. Sunrise. But! Science has subsequently explained the actual patterns of the earth's rotation. So that's why this statue is no longer worshiped, but sits in a museum. Can we go now?

SHELLY: But did the artist really believe in Ra or was he trying to do what I'm trying to do?

RUSSELL: I'd call this guy "beast" before I'd call him "beauty."

SHELLY: Stop joking, Russell! Look at this one. She's Ra's daughter, Basket.

RUSSELL: Who were the first people to keep cats as pets? (*Before SHELLY can answer.*) Egyptians! (*Congratulating himself.*) Score!

SHELLY: She's a goddess!

RUSSELL: Who had the power to ensure a bountiful harvest. The Egyptians had gods for everything-the sky, the earth, the river. So did the Greeks,

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the Romans, the Aztecs. It's Ancient Cultures 101. Myths. Hello?! To explain why things are the way they are.

SHELLY: But why?

RUSSELL: Why what?

SHELLY: Why do we need to know?

RUSSELL: We're human. We don't like not knowing.

SHELLY: But what if we can never know some things, but we wonder about them anyway.

RUSSELL: Wonder equals confusion. I don't like to be confused.

SHELLY: Mysteries. You like reading mysteries.

RUSSELL: Sure, because you always find out who did it at the end.

SHELLY: So because we're human we take all the big wonders and urn them into stories that we can understand-turn them into statues that look like us?

RUSSELL: (*referring to RA*) I know I've got a bad haircut but I don't have falcon head and you don't have cat ears!

SHELLY: But we've got arms and legs. Here's all he mystery of how the sun rises and sets, of how things grow reduced down to figures we can recognize.

RUSSELL: (*looking at the statues, dubiously*) Well…

SHELLY: OK, almost recognize. They feel so…small for something so big.

RUSSELL: Shel. The ancient Egyptians just didn't know what we know today.

SHELLY: What *do* we know?

RUSSELL: Everything.

SHELLY: Beauty…myster…everything?

RUSSELL: Sure.

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SHELLY: (*looking at her sketch*) This drawing's not working.

RUSSELL: (*deliberately*) So let's go!

SHELLY: (*flips another page*) Tell me how to do it, Russell.

RUSSELL: Me?! (*RUSSELL's cell phone rings.*) Got to answer this.

SHELLY: Answer *me*!

RUSSELL: Text message. Dad! Oh great!

SHELLY: Stop the clock. (*SHELLY grabs the phone and crosses away from him.*)

RUSSELL: Careful with the technology!

SHELLY: (*punching in keys*) "Dad. Trying to figure out the mystery of the universe. Might take us a minute. Back soon." (*Pushing the off key.*) Off. Here. (*SHELLY tosses the cell phone back to RUSSELL.*)

RUSSELL: (*catching it*) Watch it! You want to break it?

SHELLY: You mean your phone god is not indestructible as well as all-knowing?

RUSSELL: I'd sacrifice small mammals to this thing, OK?

SHELLY: I thought you just said we'd evolved since ancient times.

RUSSELL: You have exactly two minutes before we catch a cab.

SHELLY: But you know everything-

RUSSELL: We made a deal!

SHELLY: Don't you?

RUSSELL: (*reactivating the timer*) Go! (*SHELLY opens her sketchbook again. RUSSELL looks at the statues.*)

SHELLY: Look up God.

RUSSELL: Pardon?

SHELLY: On your phone. Get a definition on-line for God.

RUSSELL: That's too weird.

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SHELLY: I'm trying to draw God now.

RUSSELL: What happened to beauty?

SHELLY: Ask it!

RUSSELL: It's a cell phone. Not an oracle!

SHELLY: It's all the wonders of the universe smushed into a little black rectangle, isn't it? Makes the sun rise and set! Worshiped by many, but none more than my brother.

RUSSELL: Oh! You think I'm like the guy who carved these statues-that I've made a god out of a thing.

SHELLY: You've made a god out of having the answers! Of being so sure of yourself that you're afraid! Afraid to wonder about a question that might be too big to answer. Here! (*Shoving the sketchbook toward him.*) *You* draw beauty…God…everything!

RUSSELL: (*snatching the sketchbook*) Fine. And I *won't* draw my phone! (*RUSSELL sits to draw.*)

SHELLY: You'll draw yourself. (*This lands on RUSSELL. He puts the pencil down.*)

RUSSELL: (*genuinely*) Shelly. I don't know what to draw.

SHELLY: Honest?

RUSSELL: I don't know, OK? Maybe it's…impossible. (*SHELLY crosses and sits next to her brother. She looks at the sketchbook.*)

SHELLY: You did it.

RUSSELL: What? It's blank. There's nothing there.

SHELLY: Or everything's there.

RUSSELL: (*liking that idea*) Huh. You think?

SHELLY: I wonder!

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RUSSELL: (*acknowledging his sister*) Yes you do.

SHELLY: (*realizing the time*) We gotta go! (*SHELLY quickly gathers her things. RUSSELL stands, too, but is not rushed.*)

RUSSELL: See ya, Ra. Bastet.

SHELLY: (*to the statues*) Guess you're beautiful pars of a great big whole. You, too, phone. Full of myster and power. Maybe nothing can capture the whole. Maybe we shouldn't try.

RUSSELL: Wanna walk back?

SHELLY: Really?

RUSSELL: Sure. Lots to wonder at out there.

SHELLY: Yeah.

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